opinion of me. It seemed that she didn't. Or else, given her tone, her coldness, the opinion wasn't much.

Then one Christmas she cleared up the mystery. The whole family gathered to open gifts on Christmas Eve, as always, a German tradition that survived the anglicizing of the family surname from Saxe-Coburg-Gotha to Windsor. We were at Sandringham in a big room with a long table covered with white cloth and white name cards. By custom, at the start of the night, each of us located our place, stood before our mound of presents. Then suddenly, everyone began opening at the same time. A free-for-all, with scores of family members talking at once and pulling at bows and tearing at wrapping paper.

Standing before my pile, I chose to open the smallest present first. The tag said: *From Aunt Margo.*

I looked over, called out: *Thank you, Aunt Margo!*

I do hope you like it, Harry.

I tore off the paper. It was…

A biro?

I said: *Oh. A biro. Wow.*

She said: *Yes. A biro.*

I said: *Thank you so much.*

But it wasn't just any biro, she pointed out. It had a tiny rubber fish wrapped around it.

I said: *Oh. A* fish *biro! OK.*

I told myself: That is cold-blooded.

Now and then, as I grew older, it struck me that Aunt Margo and I should've been friends. We had so much in common. Two Spares. Her relationship with Granny wasn't an *exact* analog of mine with Willy, but pretty close. The simmering rivalry, the intense competition (driven largely by the older sibling), it all looked familiar. Aunt Margo also wasn't that dissimilar from Mummy. Both rebels, both labeled as sirens. (Pablo Picasso was among the many men obsessed with Margo.) So my first thought when I learned in early 2002 that she'd been taken ill was to wish there'd been more time to get to know her. But we were well past that. She was unable to care for herself. After badly burning her feet in a bath, she was confined to a wheelchair, and said to be swiftly declining.

When she died, February 9, 2002, my first thought was that this would be a heavy blow to Gan-Gan, who was also in decline.